

Resource inbox: creator links that stop burying your friends

Creators run comment-to-DM automations. The link lands in the same inbox as your friends, so the link gets buried and so does your friend's chat. **DM to Link** keeps every DM where it is, takes automated DMs out of the main list, and opens them into a library of the reels and posts you commented on.

What's in here

- Before: a real creator interaction, then today's flooded inbox and its pain points
- What creators send, and how each pattern shows up in the chat
- After: friends first, DM to Link, the resource card, Waiting rows
- Delivery rules, noise, and the later version
- Decisions we made and options we left for later
- Assumptions and metrics

About the screens

Captured from a clickable prototype that borrows Instagram's look so the flow feels real. It is a concept, not Instagram's UI, and nothing here detects links from real messages. Handles and people are invented.

Scope

Proposed, to confirm

V1. The core fix, and it has to be trustworthy: friends first with the floating banner, DM to Link home (Waiting on you, Waiting for link, Pinned, Recent), the resource card with a Pin button, Go to chat, every delivery pattern and edge case, and noise tucked away.

Later version

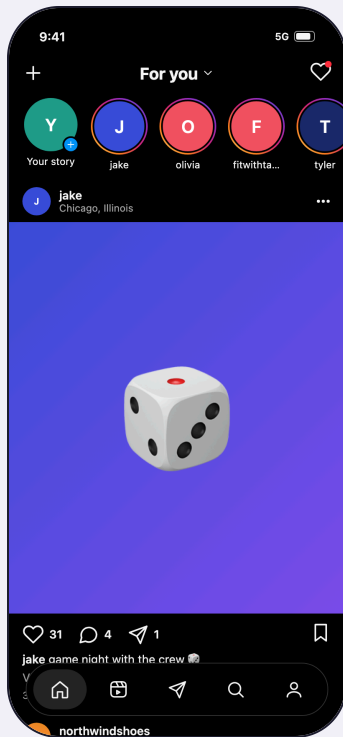
The double-tap pin gesture, search by memory with recent searches, topic rows with See all and Customize topics, renaming a resource, Creators you engaged with and creator pages, and Recent cards grouped by creator.

Why this split: V1 fixes the two problems, friends buried and links lost. The later version helps finding things once the library grows.

How a real creator interaction goes

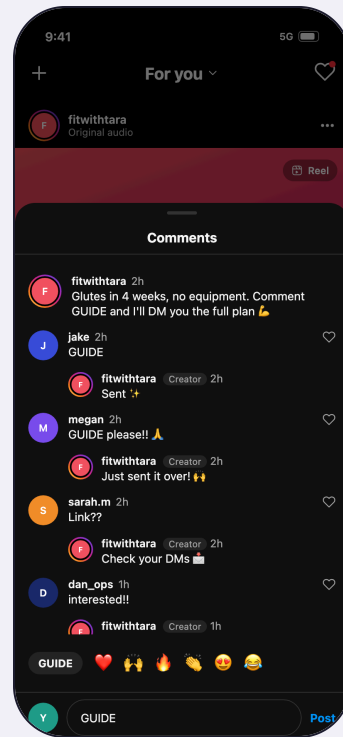
Before 1 of 2

Modelled on a real comment-to-DM automation. You comment, the creator replies in public, and a DM arrives with a red number.



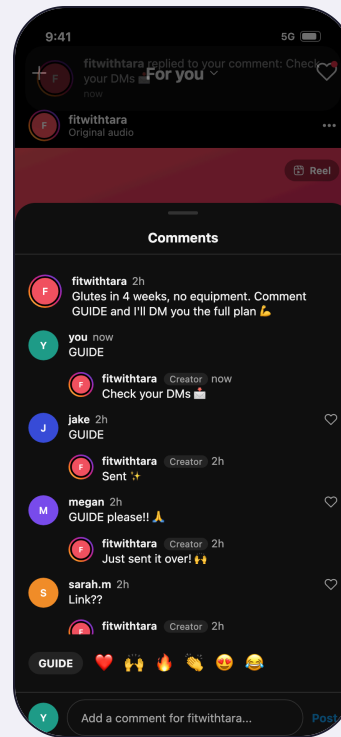
1 Feed

The reel sits among friends' posts, an ad and stories.



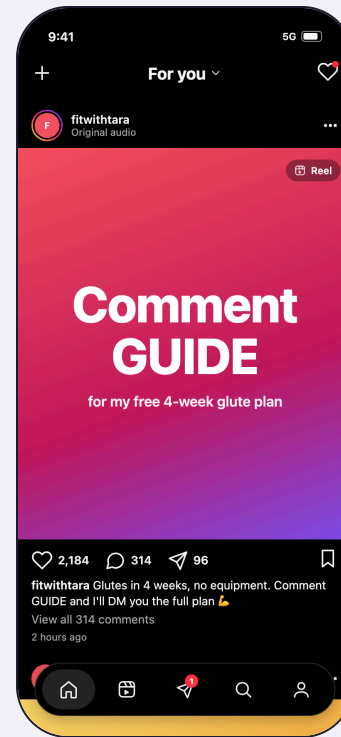
2 You comment

You type the keyword and tap Post. Others have already commented the same.



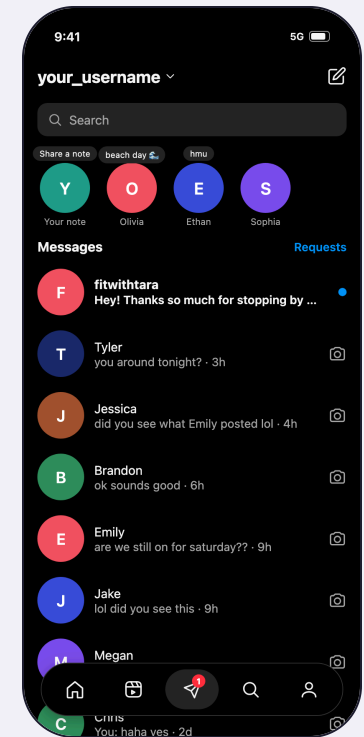
3 Public reply

The creator replies under your comment, then a notification. Reply wording varies.



4 Red number

The DM tab shows a red 1 after the DM arrives.



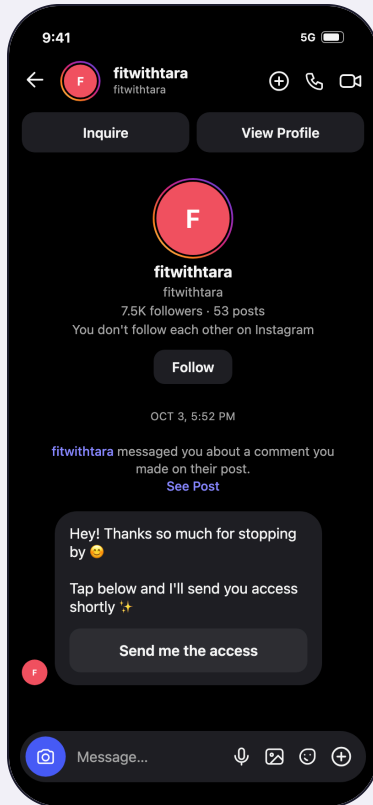
5 Unread thread

The creator's thread is first in Messages, bold with a blue dot.

How a real creator interaction goes

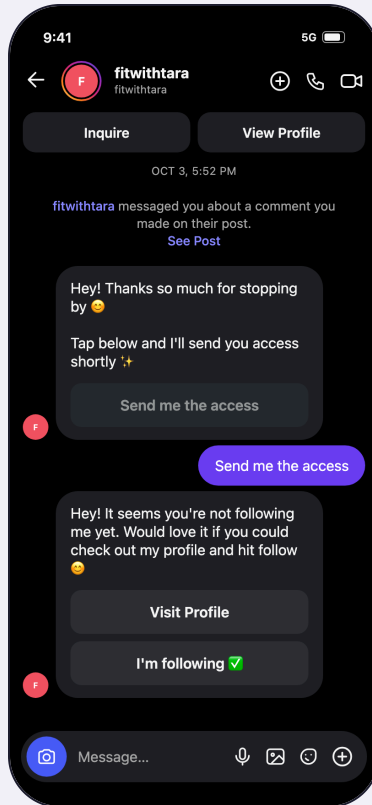
Before 2 of 2

Inside the thread the creator asks you to respond. Every response comes from your side before the resource arrives.



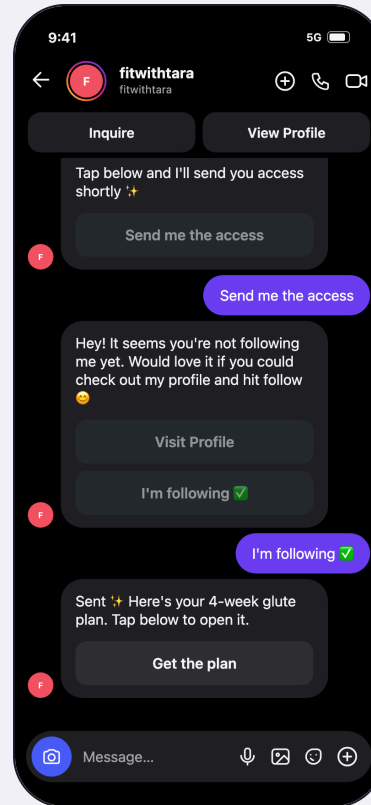
6 The thread opens

A button asks you to tap for access.



7 Follow gate

Your tap is your own message. The creator then asks for a follow.



8 Link delivered

The delivered message has an opener, text and a button.

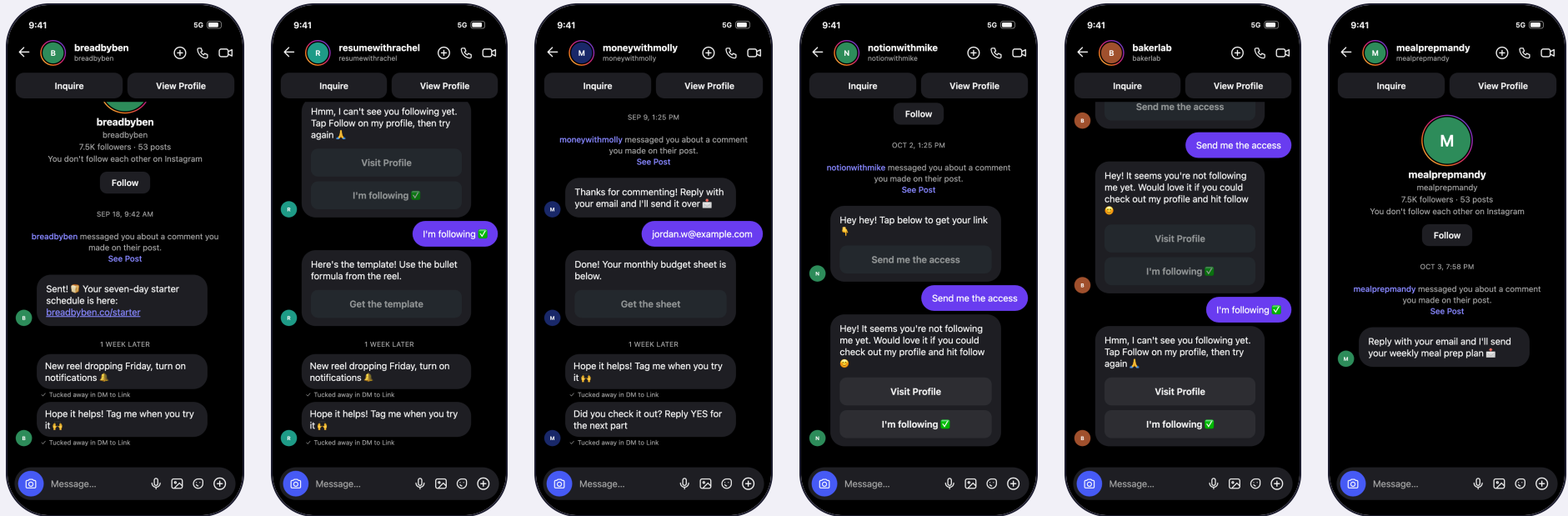
What to notice

- You always answer first. A button tap, a keyword, a follow or a typed reply shows as a purple message from you.
- The gate repeats if you tap "I'm following" before you follow. You follow from the profile, then tap again.
- The word "Sent" is not a separate message. It sits in the delivered text, or in the comment reply.
- Follow-ups and promos arrive after the link and bury it over the following weeks.

What creators send

Before

Creators vary. The prototype shows the patterns we expect, and each resource card is delivered in its own chat the same way. Your response always comes before the resource.



Link in text

The link sits in the message and is tappable.

Gate twice

Two follow taps, then the template.

Typed reply

You send your email, then the sheet.

Gate, waiting on you

Visit Profile and I'm following are live.

Repeated gate

One retry already used. Still waiting on you.

Typed ask

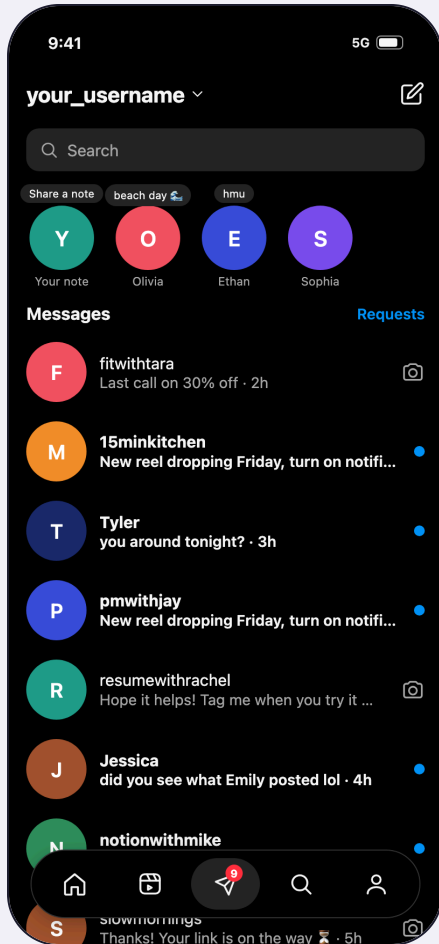
They asked for your email. You have not replied.

Other patterns in the prototype: a URL button sent right after your comment, a tap to get access, a keyword reply ("Reply YES"), and a message with a clickable link on every bullet. A creator who has not delivered yet shows only an acknowledgement, which becomes Waiting for link.

Before: weeks later, the inbox is flooded

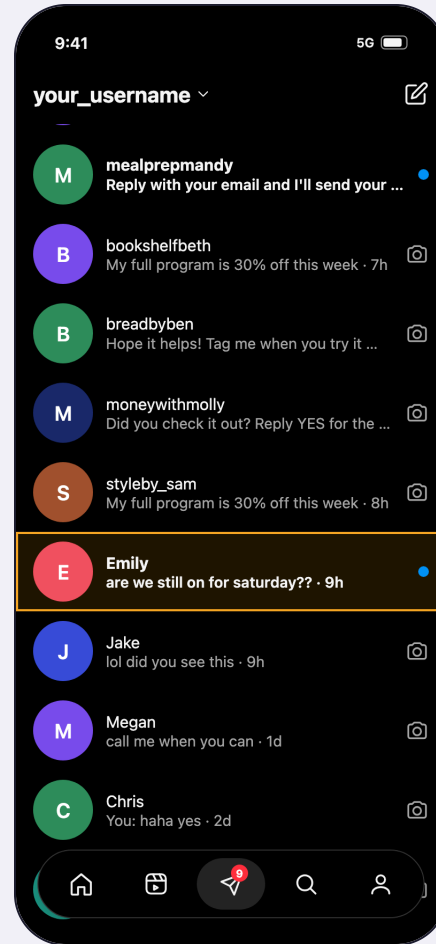
Before

Creator threads and their follow-ups take over the inbox. Friends and links both get lost.



Flooded inbox

22 threads. Unread friends sit between creator threads. The thread where the link arrived looks read.



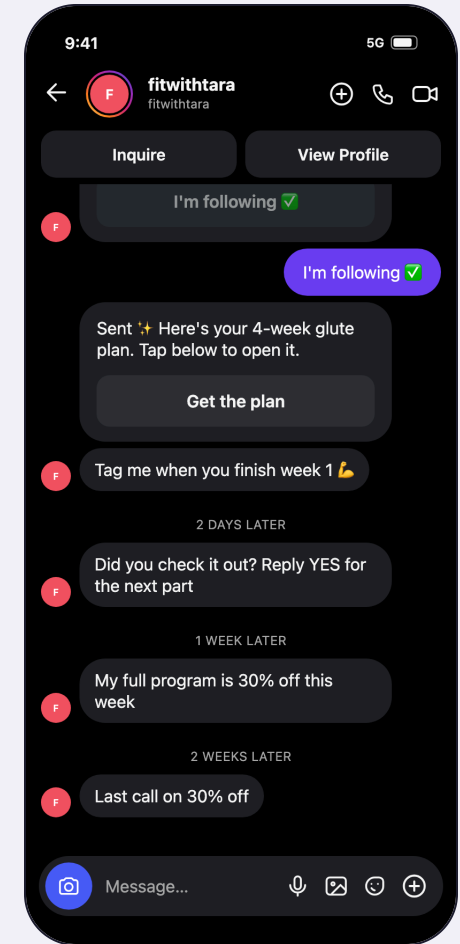
A friend is buried

Emily's unread message is 18th, under creator promos.



Search finds nothing

Messages search matches names and accounts. "pasta" returns no results.

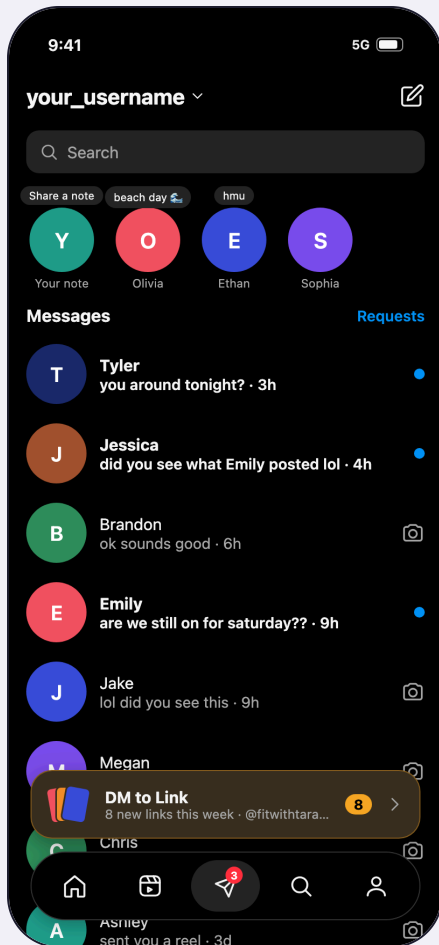


Scrolling for the link

The link sits far above the follow-ups and promos.

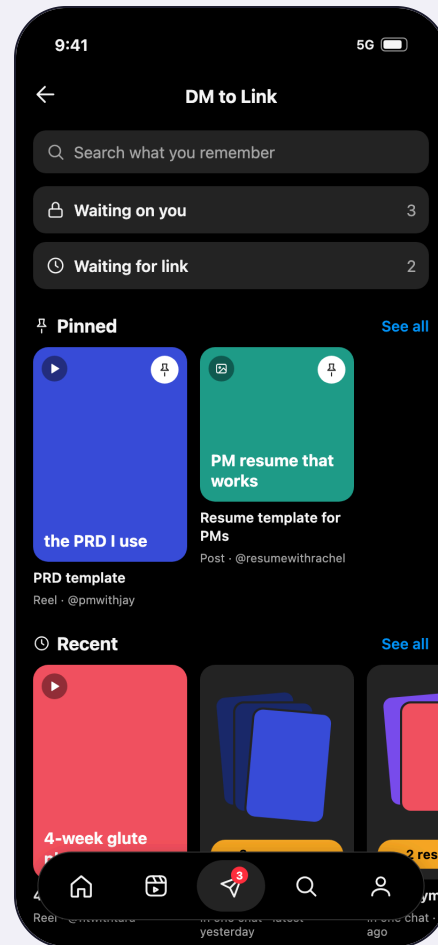
After: friends first, links in DM to Link V1

Same DMs, nothing deleted. Automated DMs leave the main list and open into a library of what you asked for.



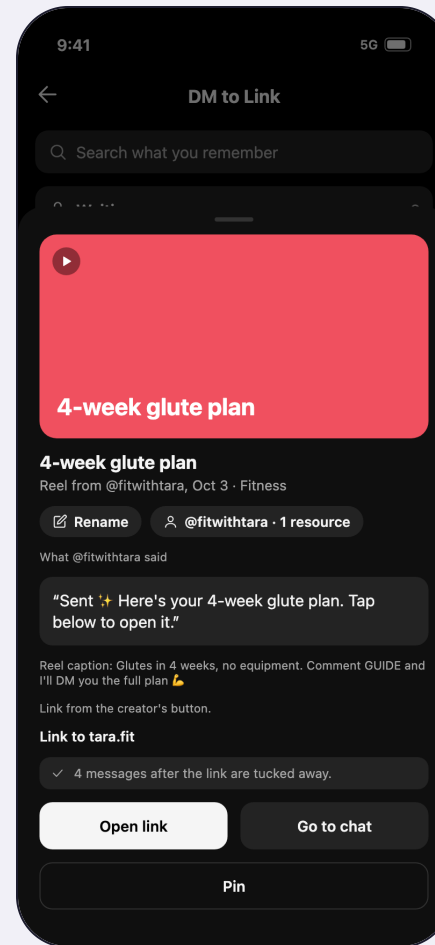
Friends first

Only friends in the list. The red number counts friends only. A floating banner above the tab bar opens DM to Link.



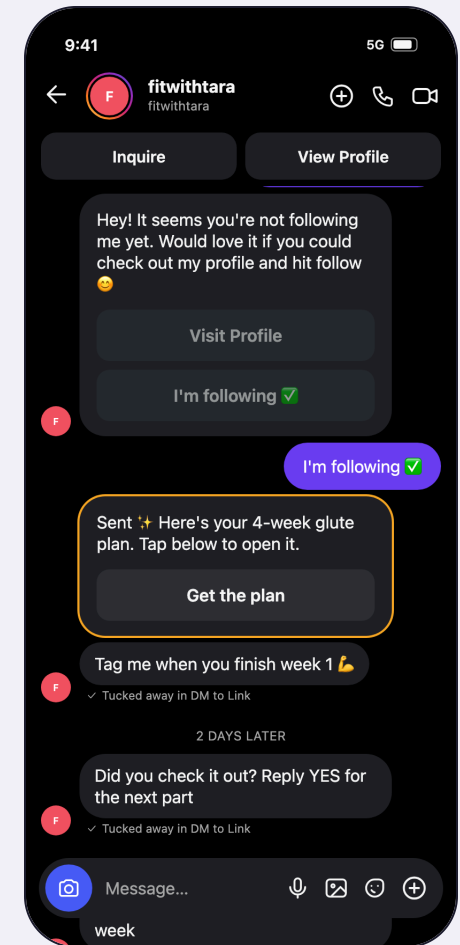
DM to Link

Waiting on you and Waiting for link on top, then Pinned and Recent. Rows scroll sideways.



Resource card

What the creator said, a clipped caption, the link's domain, Open link, Go to chat, Pin.

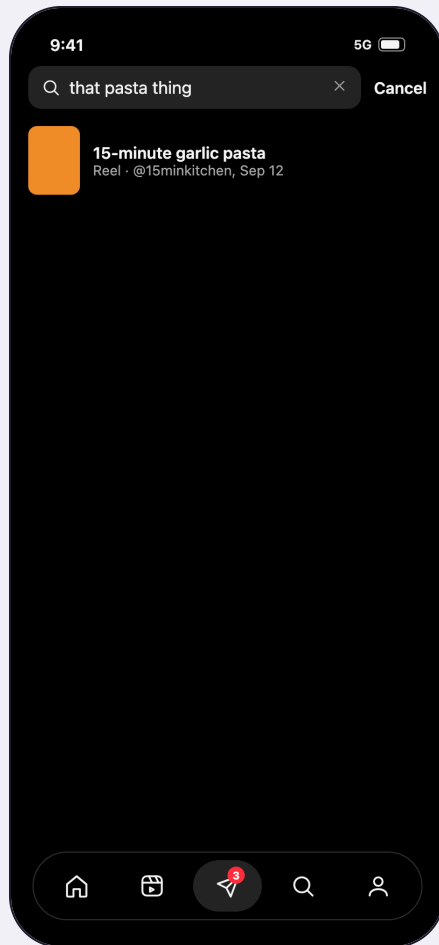


Go to chat

Opens the thread with the delivered message highlighted. Messages after the link are marked as tucked away.

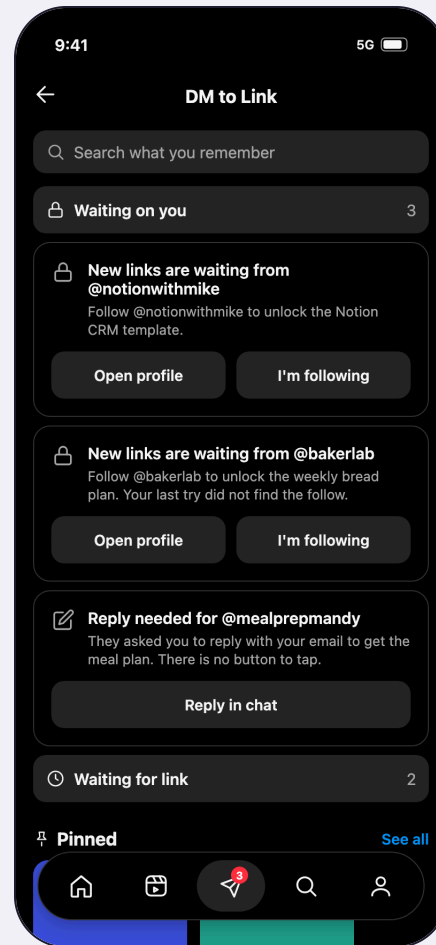
After: finding it and the Waiting rows V1

The contrast with Before: search finds the pasta recipe, and anything that needs you or the creator is visible.



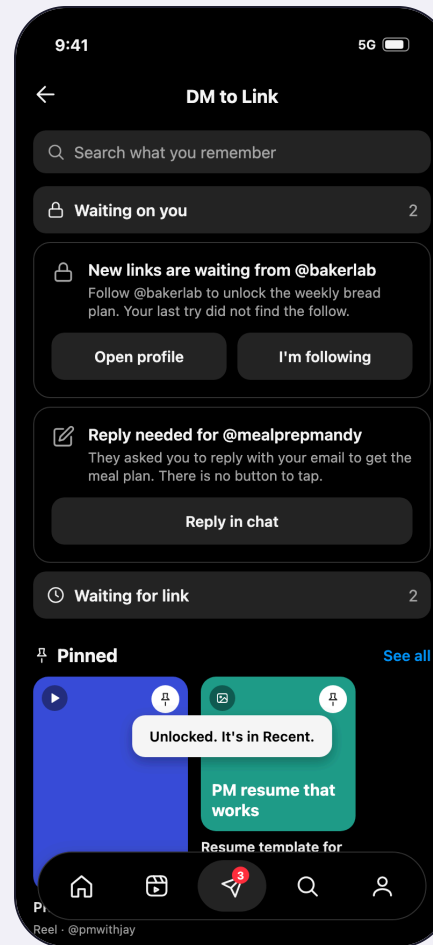
Search finds it

"that pasta thing" matches what the reel was about, not just names. (Search is later version.)



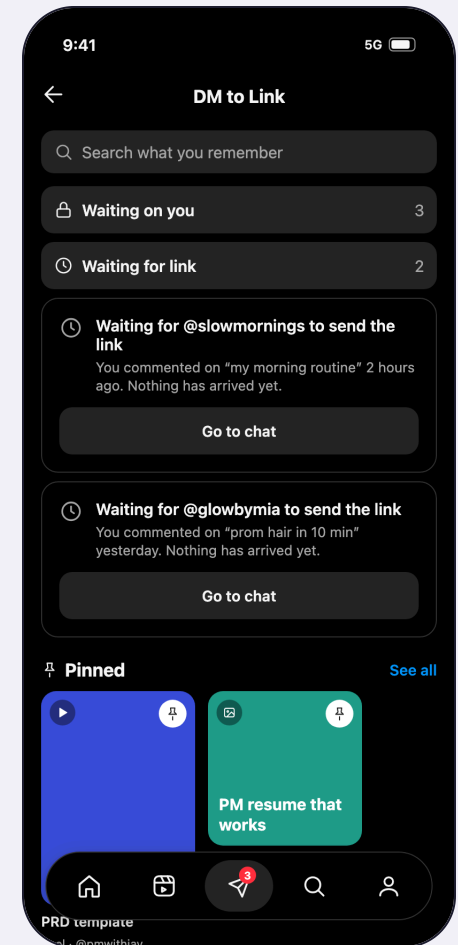
Waiting on you

"New links are waiting from @xyz" with Open profile and I'm following. Typed asks get Reply in chat.



Unlocked

After you follow and tap, the card leaves Waiting on you and moves into Recent with a toast.



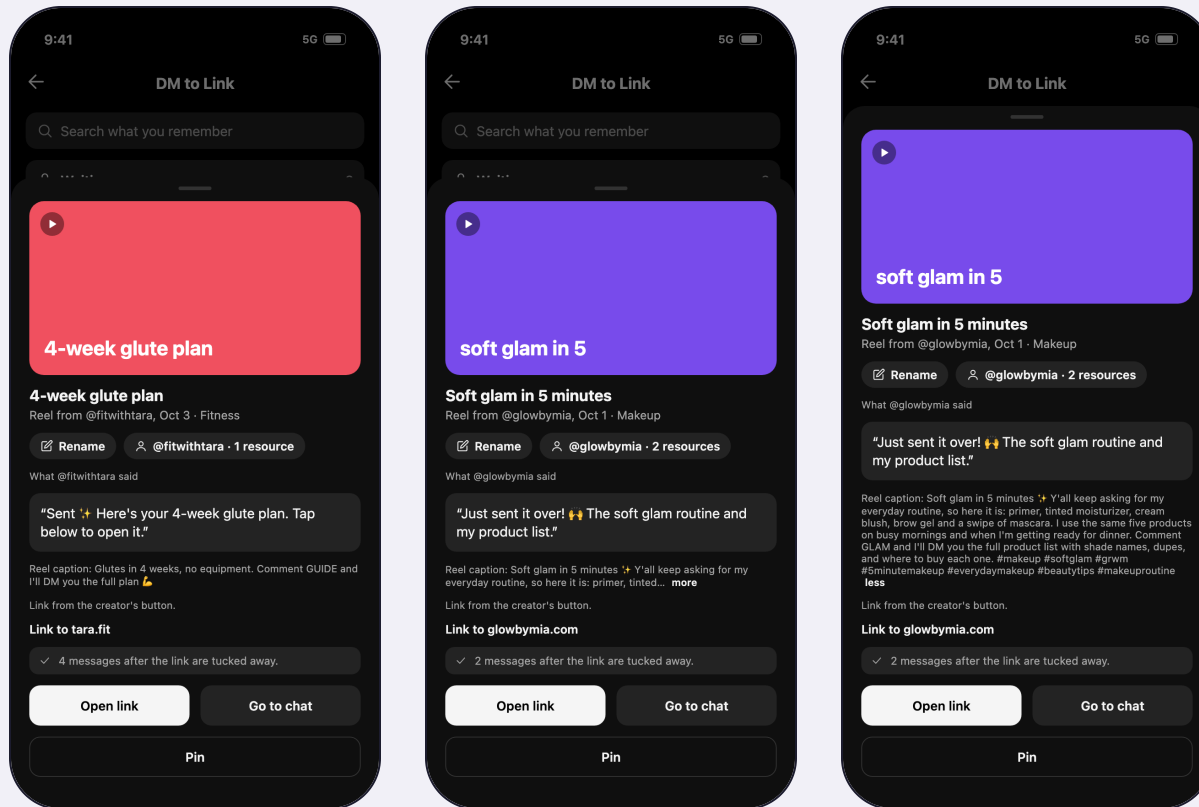
Waiting for link

You commented and nothing has arrived. Go to chat shows the acknowledgement.

The resource card, without the bloat

V1

Captions can be long. Cards show only the title. The detail sheet clips the caption and keeps the full text one tap away.



Short caption

Shown whole. No toggle.

Long caption, clipped

About 110 characters, trailing hashtags stripped, with "more."

Expanded

The full text, with "less" to collapse.

Rules

- No AI summary. Some reels have no caption or speech, and generating one costs more and can invent detail.
- Show what the creator said (their DM text) and the clipped caption.
- Search still reads the full caption, even when it is hidden.
- A message with a link on every bullet is shown in full on purpose, so each link stays tappable.

How a link counts as delivered V1

Decide by deliverable, not button type. This replaces the first draft's "first outside link" rule.

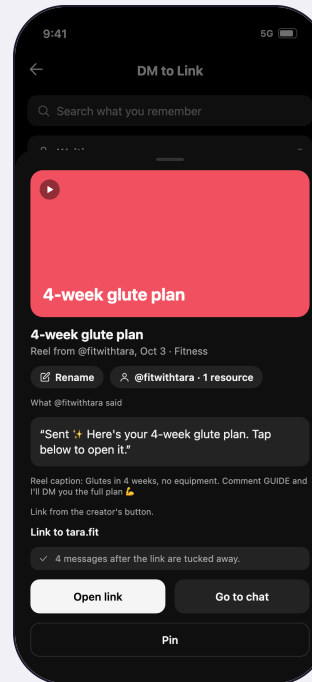
The rule

A sequence starts at the private reply to your comment. We scan that creator's later messages for a deliverable: a URL button, a URL in the message text, or a file or media attachment. [instagram.com](https://www.instagram.com) links never count.

- **Deliverable found:** Delivered.
- **None yet, and the latest message waits on a tap or a typed reply:** Waiting on you.
- **You did your part and nothing has arrived:** Waiting for link.

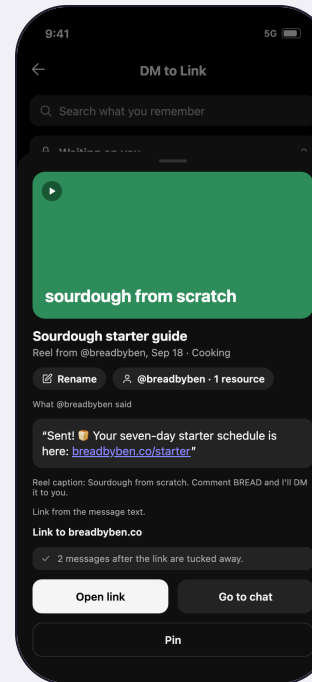
Cases

- **Link in a button** counts, and the card says so.
- **Link in the text** is picked up and shown as a link.
- **A message with a link per bullet** is the resource. It opens in full.
- **A prompt after delivery** ("Reply YES for the next part") is noise, not a gate.
- Later checkout links stay in the thread. Linked files behind a login are never read.
- Links show their domain only. We do not expand shortened links.



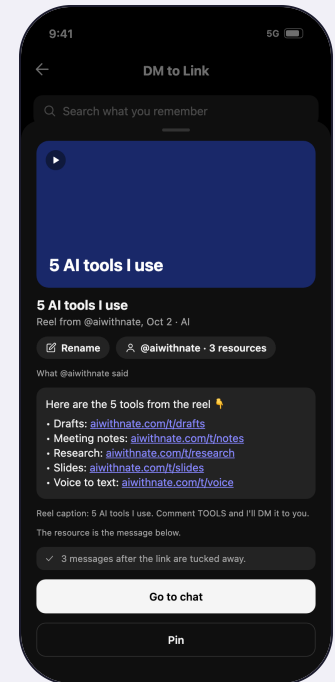
In a button

"Link from the creator's button."



In the text

Picked up and tappable.



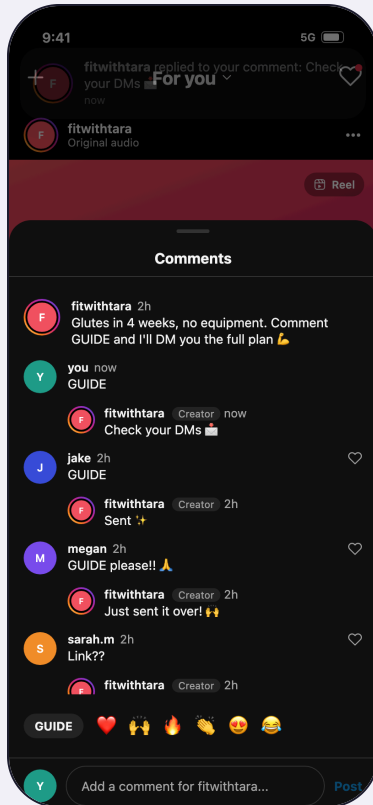
Link per bullet

Shown in full.

Noise is tucked away, not deleted

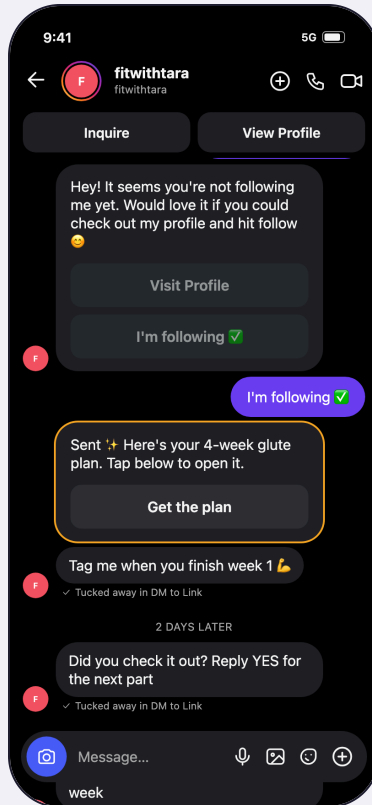
V1

DM to Link tucks away what a creator sends after your link arrives. Comments and their replies are left alone.



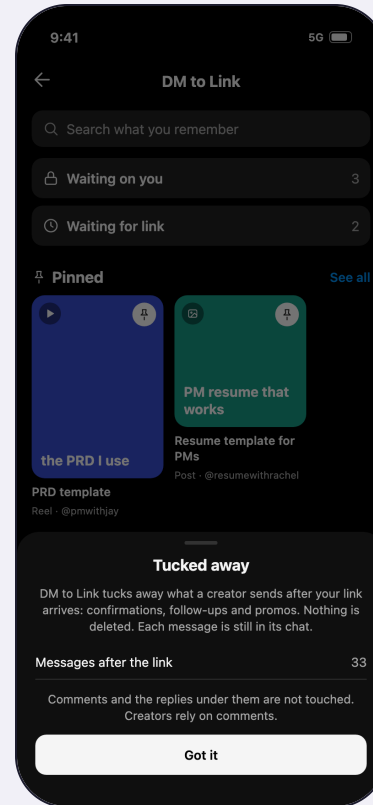
Comments stay put

Creators' public replies stay in the comments, where creators count engagement.



Marked in the chat

Messages after the link carry a small "Tucked away" note.



Counted

One category, with the total.

What gets tucked away

- Confirmations, follow-ups and promos a creator sends after the link.
- Defined by position, not by wording, because creators write their own replies.

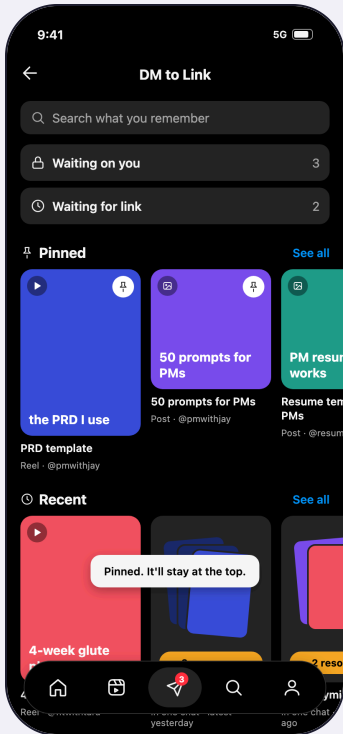
What does not

- Public replies and notifications under your comments.
- Anything before the link is delivered.
- Your own messages and button taps.

Later version: pin, search and topics

Later version

Ways to find things once the library grows. The Pin button on the resource card is V1. The gesture and the rest come later.



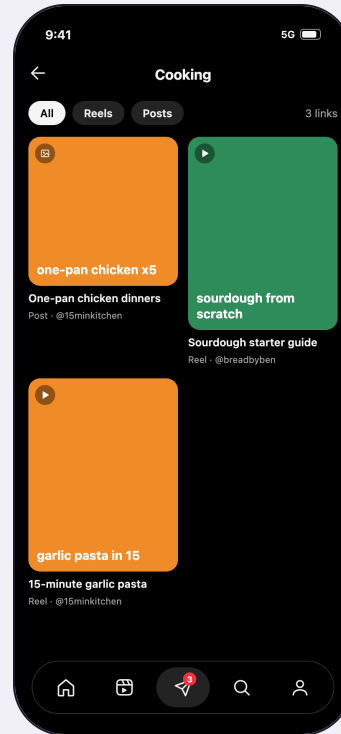
Double-tap to pin

Pinned items move to the top row.



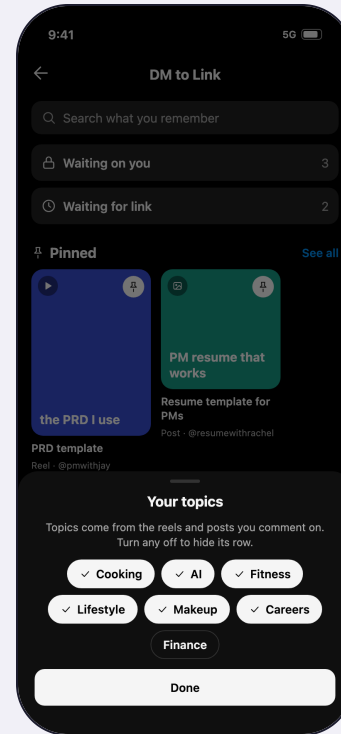
Recent searches

"that pasta thing" is a recent search you can delete.



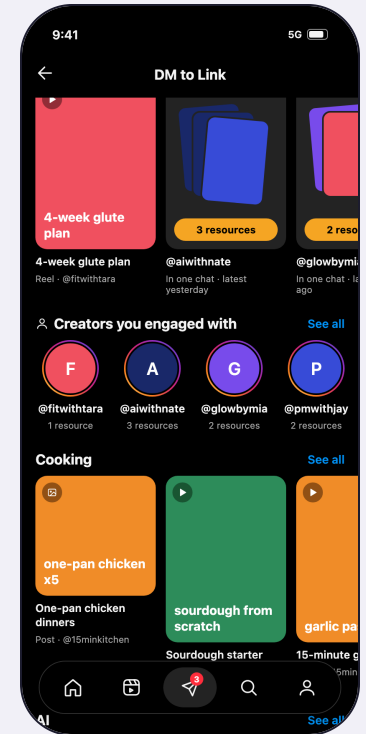
See all

Reels and posts, with All, Reels and Posts filters.



Customize topics

Topics come from what you comment on. Turn any off.



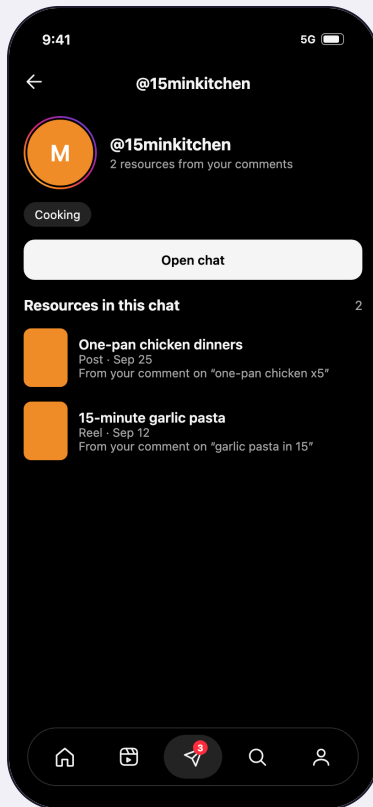
Recent and creators

One card per creator when they sent several.

Later version: creators and renaming

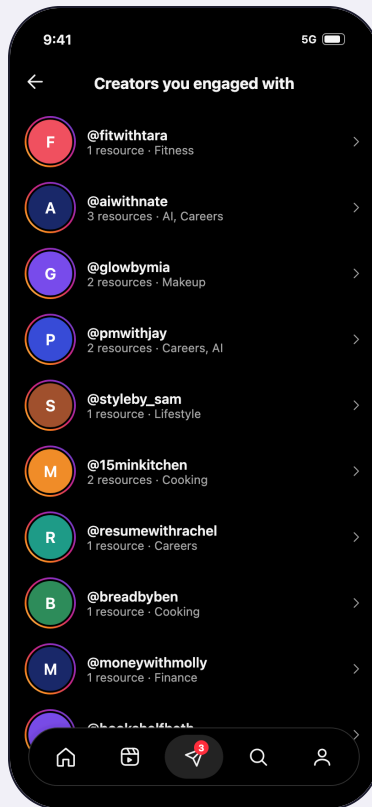
Later version

One creator can send many links, and a handle can be just a name. Browse by creator, and rename a single resource. Creators themselves are not renamed.



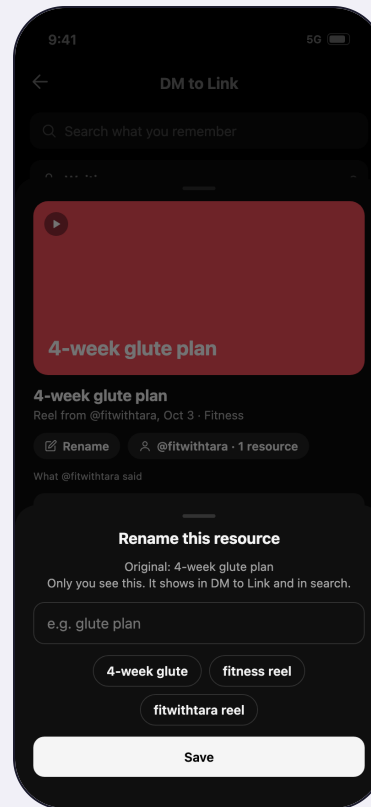
Creator page

Their chat and every resource, each tied to the comment that triggered it.



Creators you engaged with

The full list, most recent first.



Rename a resource

One-tap suggestions from the topic and title. Only you see it.

Why no creator labels

- Creators' reach and engagement are the point for Instagram, and creator names are not ours to customize.
- Topic tags already tell you what a creator shares.
- Renaming one resource is enough to find "that pasta thing."

Decisions and options we left for later

The rule we used: keep a feature if it is low effort or high value, and drop it if it is mid-to-high effort for low value.

ITEM	EFFORT	VALUE	CALL	WHY
Red number on the DM tab, unread thread first	Low	High	Keep	Makes the story feel real and shows the badge inflation problem.
Creator thread generated for every resource	Mid	High	Keep	Cards and chats must agree, and your response must come first.
Waiting on you, Waiting for link	Low	High	Keep	Separates "you need to act" from "the creator has not sent."
Clipped caption with more/less	Low	High	Keep	Long captions would bloat the card.
AI summary on the card	Mid-high	Low-mid	Drop	Not always possible, costs more, and can invent detail.
Expanding shortened links	Mid-high	Low	Drop	Instagram already checks links and opens its own browser. We show the domain only.
Creator labels	Built	Low	Removed	Tags already cover it. Resource rename is kept.
Combined "Follow and continue" button	Mid	Mid	Later	Follow state is checkable, but the creator's tool resumes on your own "I'm following" tap. Two buttons for V1.
Forward a resource to a friend	Low-mid	Low-mid	Later	If built, forward the reel or post only, so the friend triggers their own DM and the creator keeps the engagement.

Assumptions and metrics

What this concept depends on, and how I would measure it. Metrics are proposals with no data behind them yet.

Assumptions

- Automated DMs are identifiable because tools like ManyChat send through the Messaging API. Meta's docs show an echo flag on app-sent messages.
- The first DM is a Private Reply tied to the comment. The docs allow one message per comment, within 7 days.
- Later messages in the sequence are tied to the comment by time window, not by ID. Two comments on two posts by one creator the same day are ambiguous.
- Button URLs are readable as structured data. The docs show URL buttons carry a type, url and title.
- Follow state is checkable. The user profile API exposes whether the user follows the account.
- Reel captions are available. Linked files behind a login are never read.

Not confirmed

- Which attachment types Instagram DMs allow from automations.
- Whether a private reply's first message can carry a button template.
- How encrypted chats or data exports treat these messages.
- That DM search matches names and accounts only, as shown in Before.
- Whether Instagram would fire the creator's "I'm following" tap for you.
- Feasibility: Instagram itself can build this. A third-party app only sees messages for creator accounts that connect it.

Proposed metrics

- Taps to open a friend's chat for heavy commenters, before vs. after.
- 7-day revisit rate on resources delivered by automation.
- Comment-to-DM participation per user over 90 days, to check that a cleaner inbox does not reduce commenting.
- Share of resources opened after day 7.
- Time to find a resource by search, and searches that end in an opened resource (later version).
- Share of resources pinned or renamed (later version).

Open questions

- How reliably can gated messages be told apart from delivered ones across automation tools?
- Does a button tap weeks later still return the link from every tool?
- How long does a sequence stay open before we call it Waiting for link?
- Do data exports keep button URLs? A cheap test: run a comment-to-DM flow with a URL button on a test account, then check the export.
- Where does the first draft's "Older after 30 days" group live in the new layout?